

The reply game and reaching out first

Week 3, Lecture 2 · Grow on X: From Zero to 10,000 Followers

Autumn 2026

What we'll cover

- Why replying matters more than posting at zero followers
- Borrowed distribution: using another account's reach as your stage
- Choosing targets: 10x-100x your size, same niche
- Reply patterns that generate profile clicks
- DMs and follow-firsts: reaching out without making it transactional

By the end of this lecture you can run a reply sprint, evaluate whether any given account is better reached by reply or DM, and explain the Paul Graham principle behind it all.

The distribution problem at zero followers

Why posting cold does not work

- At zero followers your posts reach near-zero people in the first 30 minutes
- Low initial engagement tells the algorithm the post is low quality
- The algorithm restricts reach further, producing even lower engagement
- The cycle reinforces itself: small audience, small signal, smaller distribution

You cannot engineer engagement velocity when you have no audience to seed it.

Borrowed distribution: the core insight

- When you reply to a post by a large account, your reply appears below theirs in the thread
- Readers of the original post see your name and handle
- A reply with genuine value earns profile clicks from an audience that already trusts the original account
- You did not grow your audience to access that reach. You borrowed it through the reply.

This is not a trick. It is how every creator finds their first 500 followers.

The order-of-magnitude argument

- A creator with zero followers publishing a post reaches: 0-20 people in the first wave
- A reply on a post by an account with 25,000 followers reaches: thousands of readers who are already in the thread
- The difference is 2-3 orders of magnitude, available at no cost except the quality of the reply

Replies are the only format where your distribution is not limited by your own follower count.

Do things that don't scale

Paul Graham's principle applied to creator growth

Graham (2013): "The most common unscalable thing founders have to do at the start is to recruit users manually."

Applied to X:

- Manually finding target posts and writing specific replies does not scale
- Manually DM-ing people with genuine, specific messages does not scale
- That is exactly why it works: it cannot be automated or faked at volume

The creators who grow from 0 to 10k do the unscalable work first.

Why manual outreach compounds

- The first 500 followers are the hardest: no social proof, no visibility, no algorithm momentum
- Manual replies produce real conversations, which produce profile clicks, which produce follows
- Each follow raises your baseline reach on the next post
- At 500 followers you have enough seed engagement to start using velocity properly

Manual effort in weeks 1-6 buys organic reach in weeks 7-12.

Choosing targets

The 10x-100x rule

- Target accounts 10 to 100 times your size in the same niche
- 10x-50x: small enough that your reply is visible; large enough that their audience is meaningful
- 100x+: your reply disappears in the thread and the account rarely notices new voices
- Same niche: their followers are your potential followers

If you have 200 followers, target accounts with 2,000-20,000.

What makes a good target account

Good targets:

- Post regularly (at least three times per week)
- Have active comment sections (replies already happening)
- Address the same reader you address
- Have posted in the last two hours (your reply still gets seen)

Avoid:

- Accounts that never reply to commenters (no conversation to join)
- Accounts posting viral memes (comments are noise, not your audience)
- Accounts in adjacent niches where their followers would not follow you

Replies that generate profile clicks

What makes a reply earn the click

Three patterns that work:

1. **Specific addition:** cite a number, name, or example the original post omitted
2. **Complication:** name one condition under which the claim does not hold
3. **Direct answer:** if the post asks a question, answer it briefly and specifically

Length: 2-4 sentences. Long enough to show substance; short enough to read in the thread.

What destroys a reply

Patterns that earn zero profile clicks:

- "Great point!" or any generic agreement
- Promoting your own content in the reply body
- A question that requires the original poster to do work ("have you tried X?")
- A reply that restates the original post in different words
- A link to anything

None of these give the reader a reason to click your profile.

A worked example

Original post: "Most creators quit before the algorithm starts working for them."

Weak reply: "So true! Consistency is key. I've been posting for two months and seeing growth!"

Strong reply: "Metricool's 2024 study across 23,000 accounts found that posting frequency correlates with account size. But the accounts that stopped did not fail because they posted too little. They failed because they posted without feedback loops. Knowing when to adjust matters as much as showing up."

The strong reply teaches something. The weak one performs agreement.

DMs and follow-firsts

When to DM instead of reply

Use a DM when:

- The insight is too long or personal for a public reply
- You want to start a conversation that benefits from privacy
- You have something specific and useful to say about their recent work

Do not DM when:

- You want a follow-back
- You want them to share your content
- You have nothing specific to say

The test: could this DM have been sent to any creator in the niche, or is it specific to this person?

DM structure that does not feel transactional

Observation: one specific thing from their recent content

Why it resonated: one sentence connecting it to your own work or thinking

No ask: end the message without requesting anything

Example:

"Your thread on reply timing yesterday matched something I've been noticing with my own replies: the 60-minute window closes faster than I expected. I adjusted my notification setup based on it."

That DM has no ask. It is a real observation. It can start a real conversation.

Follow-firsts as a signal

- Following an account before replying signals genuine interest, not cold outreach
- The account sees the notification; they may check your profile before you even reply
- The follow costs nothing and frames every subsequent interaction as "this is a reader, not a stranger"
- Combined with a substantive reply, a follow-first positions you as a peer, not a supplicant

Follow-first, reply within 24 hours, DM within 48. That sequence reads as organic.

The reply-to-follow funnel

```
Reply posted (in target account's thread)
  |
Reader sees reply, finds it interesting
  |
Reader clicks your profile
  |
Profile bio converts the click into a follow
```

Every step in this funnel was introduced in earlier weeks. The algorithm lecture (L1) explains reach. Hook and bio lectures (wk01-02) explain conversion. The reply game connects them.

Take-aways

1. At zero followers, replying to larger accounts is the only way to access meaningful distribution without paying for it.
2. Graham's "do things that don't scale" principle predicts exactly this: the manual, unautomatable work is what produces early traction.
3. Target accounts 10x-100x your size in the same niche. Their audience is already your audience.
4. Reply patterns that earn profile clicks: specific addition, complication, direct answer. Generic agreement earns nothing.
5. A DM with no ask and a specific observation opens doors that a pitch closes.

"The most common unscalable thing founders have to do at the start is to recruit users manually."

Paul Graham, *Do Things that Don't Scale* (2013)

What's next

- **Section (this week):** Reply sprint. Ten target accounts, ten replies within 60 minutes, five DMs. Track profile clicks the next day.
- **Reading:** Week 3 reading at </c/grow-on-x-26au/readings/wk03> (the X algorithm and the reply game)
- **HW2 (twenty posts):** due this week
- **Week 4:** Content cadence and batching. How to post consistently without burning out.